Preserving the Information Foundation of National Security

Draft proposed written testimony for Lieutenant General Paul T. Stanton, USA — not an official or delivered statement

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Chair, Ranking Member, and Members of the Committee:

OPENING

Thank you for the opportunity to testify. When a commander needs the original record, we should be able to produce it. Not another summary. The record.

I recommend that Congress establish a focused, defense-led Strategic Information Command within the Department of Defense. Its mission: preserve defense-critical information, make it available to authorized users, and prove that it can be recovered and used. Put a commander in charge. Hold that commander accountable for results.

Our job is to get the right data to the right place at the right time so commanders can make better and faster decisions than the enemy.[1] Moving data is not enough if we cannot establish where it came from or what happened to it along the way. An original record and a summary of that record are not interchangeable. If we lose the original, we may lose the ability to check what the summary left out.[2,3]

That is the concern behind this proposal. Not a prediction that artificial intelligence will fail. Not a request to collect the entire internet. A military requirement to keep mission-critical information recoverable, traceable, and useful.

This is my recommendation, not an approved departmental position. Keep the command within the defense mission and the law. Support existing custodians. Do not take over civilian archives. Judge it by what it delivers to the force, not the size of its headquarters.

THE RISK TO THE INFORMATION BASE

Consider what happens to a maintenance report. Someone records a fault, the conditions under which it occurred, and what was done to correct it. That report can become a summary. The summary can become an answer from an artificial intelligence (AI) tool. That answer can then become material used to train another tool.[2,4]

There is nothing inherently wrong with summarizing information or generating useful training examples. The risk comes when generated material repeatedly replaces the original observations. Under some training conditions, errors can carry forward and unusual details can disappear. Later models can become less capable of representing the information they started with. Researchers call this form of deterioration across successive rounds of training **model collapse**.[5,6]

That risk has been demonstrated in controlled studies, not established as the fate of every fielded system. Keeping original data available can help in studied settings, but it does not guarantee that every detail or capability survives. Well-chosen synthetic data can improve performance on particular tasks. Other self-training approaches have failed to improve results. Even checking generated examples is only as useful as the checks themselves; a biased checker can limit or reverse the gains.[6,7,8,9]

Do not reject AI. Keep the means to check it. Preserve the observations. Track the changes. Test against the mission. Demand evidence, not reassurance.

We also need to distinguish how things go wrong. A model does not change simply because a web page changes; retraining can change what it has learned. A tool that searches outside material can give a worse answer because it found a poor source, even without retraining. An adversary can deliberately manipulate training material or the material a tool retrieves. Repeated reuse of generated material can cause problems without an adversary doing anything.[4,5] Those differences matter when deciding what to fix.

Nor does an old date make a record trustworthy. Human authors make mistakes. Instruments and software can produce valid observations. We should preserve documented observations and records with their context, not try to certify a supposedly pure internet from before AI.[2,3] And we must keep collecting fresh information. An archive should help us understand the operating environment, not become a reason to stop observing it.

WHY THIS IS A READINESS ISSUE

A confident answer is not the standard. A defensible decision is. Require information that trained people can examine and test—not merely an answer that sounds convincing.[1,2]

Here is a hypothetical example—not a reported incident. A unit moving critical supplies encounters an unexpected engine fault. A maintainer asks a decision-support tool for help. The answer is clear and confident. But an earlier inspection report described an unusual failure under those conditions, and that detail never made it into the summaries available to the tool.

Now the maintainer needs the report, not another summary. Who has it? Can it be recovered? Is it the original version? Were there later corrections? Is this person authorized to see it? Those are the questions I want the proposed command to help answer before a unit depends on the information.

Preserving that report would not fix the engine or tell the maintainer which repair is safe. It would preserve the ability to examine the evidence and test whether the tool can find and interpret it. Give the maintainer the evidence. Then test whether the tool can do its job.

The uncommon case deserves particular attention. An unusual failure or operating condition may be precisely what matters to a mission, even if it appears rarely in the records. Research showing loss of less-common information is a reason to test those cases—not evidence that a particular military system has already failed.[5,6]

Provenance means the origin and history of a record. It can help us examine where information came from and how it changed. It does not tell us that every statement in it is true.[2] Preservation should support judgment and evaluation, not replace them.

We do not need a forecast about superintelligence to act. The effects of recycled training material on hypothetical future systems remain uncertain; the studies do not establish a timetable or measured outcome for them.[5,6,9] My recommendation rests on the information needed for today's maintenance, logistics, planning, and readiness decisions. Protecting our ability to inspect and recover that information is work we can define and test now.

A FOCUSED STRATEGIC INFORMATION COMMAND

Give the command four duties. For each: a military requirement, a named owner, and a result to demonstrate. Require the Secretary of Defense to settle reporting relationships and overlaps before expansion. This is not a proposal for another global unified combatant command.

First, identify and prioritize. Start with the mission. Which information collections does a commander depend on? Which cannot be replaced? Where is the risk of loss greatest? Who is responsible for them?

The command should work with existing custodians to identify those collections and rank them by mission dependency, uniqueness, the quality of their provenance, and risk of loss. Priorities should include original government and scientific observations, authoritative technical and historical records, and lawfully held defense mission datasets. Each collection should have a named custodian, an operational purpose, and clear access and use conditions.

Do not measure this duty by how much information we can accumulate. Measure it by whether we know which information matters, who holds it, and what needs protection. The civilian internet is not a collection requirement. A defense mission should justify each priority.

Second, preserve recoverable originals. Keep the original separate from the summary, translation, cleaned dataset, or generated version. Keep the history of changes. When the origin is unknown, say so. Do not turn missing documentation into a claim that the material is trustworthy.

I recommend versioned preservation copies in geographically separated locations, with controlled access and records of custody. Check whether stored files have changed. Restore them and demonstrate that they can be read. Record what was altered and by whom when that information is available. These measures build on established preservation practices; they are not a substitute for judging the contents.[3,10]

Keep preservation within lawful retention schedules and security requirements. No blanket exemption. Do not let modernization erase the distinction between an original and a convenient copy. Improve the tools. Retain the records needed to check their work. Convenience is not a reason to discard the evidence.

Third, enable authorized, traceable use. A preserved collection should be usable by the people entitled to use it. Carry the records of origin, changes, rights, and access restrictions with it. Make clear what was observed and what was generated. A signature or a detector result can answer a limited question; neither makes the contents automatically true.[2]

Use the Defense Information Systems Agency (DISA) for its infrastructure and secure-operations expertise. Coordinate data and AI evaluation with the Chief Digital and Artificial Intelligence Office (CDAO). Work with Department records officials and component custodians. The National Archives and Records Administration (NARA) and other civilian custodians already have responsibilities that this proposal must respect.[11,12,13,3,10]

Universities, research institutions, and nongovernmental archives should participate only through lawful agreements and applicable rights and access conditions. This command should have no general power to police content, compel civilian collection, or control civilian archives. Its mission is to support defense readiness, not to decide what the public may say or read.

Fourth, demonstrate readiness. A recovery plan is not a recovery exercise. Restore the collection. Put it in the hands of authorized users. Show that they can use it. Until then, report the capability as unproven.

Run independent restoration exercises. Test data and models against the missions they support, including uncommon but consequential cases. Keep test material out of training so that a good score does not merely reflect having seen the answers. Check errors and whether the system still handles the range of cases it is meant to handle.

Report the results in terms a commander and this Committee can use: how much of the prioritized material has documented origins; what was successfully restored; how task-specific errors and coverage of different cases changed; what custody or access problems remain; and what the capability costs to sustain. These are proposed standards, not claims of present performance. Counting stored bytes cannot answer whether the force can use the information when it needs it.

CONGRESSIONAL DIRECTION AND ACCOUNTABILITY

I ask Congress for three actions.

First, authorize the mission and assign accountability. Establish the Strategic Information Command within the Department of Defense for this narrow preservation-and-assurance mission. Define its boundaries and preserve civilian control. I am requesting explicit authorization, not assuming that general organizational law already provides it.[14,15]

Give the Secretary a clear responsibility to deliver the capability. Give Congress a clear basis for oversight. Keep privacy, civil liberties, copyright, classification, and lawful access at the center of the authorization. These are operating requirements, not paperwork to complete after collection starts.

Second, require a costed, phased implementation plan. Use what already exists before building something new. The plan should show the relationship to DISA, CDAO, the Department Chief Information Officer, records officials, NARA, and other custodians. State what remains with each organization, where coordination is required, and how preservation, security, restoration, and evaluation will be funded.

Start with defined mission needs and demonstrate useful results before expanding. Require the Secretary to compare the command with strengthening existing offices and explain the additional accountability it would provide. Existing records and preservation organizations are not an institutional vacuum to be filled.[3,10,13] I recommend a command to fix responsibility and demand execution. A new headquarters is not, by itself, an improvement.

Identify duplication and the full cost of sustaining the mission. I recommend no funding amount, staffing total, or projected savings without that work. Require the command to earn its resources. Fund demonstrated capability, not expanding jurisdiction.

Third, require annual reporting and independent oversight. Have the Government Accountability Office or the Inspector General assess performance, costs, duplication, and compliance with the authorized mission. Require the reports to separate completed, independently checked work from future plans.

Congress should see restoration results, mission-specific evaluations, unresolved custody and access gaps, and lifecycle costs. Oversight should test whether privacy protections, access controls, retention rules, and civilian custodians' rights are being respected. If the mission, partners, or uses of the information change, Congress should be informed. A narrow mission must remain narrow in execution.

CLOSING

Establish the command. Assign responsibility. Resource the mission against a plan. Demand proof that it works.

Preserving records will not, by itself, produce a reliable model or a sound military decision. Losing the ability to inspect and recover them would leave us fewer ways to check either.[2,3]

Readiness is a requirement.[1] Apply it to the information our forces depend on. Know what matters. Preserve the original. Put it in authorized hands. Recover it under test. Do not confuse a plan with a capability.

I recommend that Congress establish the Strategic Information Command with that mission and those limits. Thank you. I look forward to your questions.

ENDNOTES

1. **[S003]** U.S. Senate Committee on Armed Services, *Enterprise Security and Information Technology Operations of Department of Defense Networks and Systems*, S. Hrg. 119–495, hearing March 24, 2026; GPO publication 2026. Stanton oral remarks PDF pp. 12–14 (“our weapons system, the Department of War Information Network,” right data/better and faster decisions, p. 12; “confidence in the data upon which they make their decisions,” p. 13) and his prepared statement pp. 14–17 (“one core task,” p. 14). Only Stanton’s identified remarks are used; co-witness testimony precedes his. Public source; local record: sources/stanton/S003.md.

2. **[R014]** National Institute of Standards and Technology, *Reducing Risks Posed by Synthetic Content: An Overview of Technical Approaches to Digital Content Transparency*, NIST AI 100-4, November 2024, Executive Summary and §3.1. Public source; local record: sources/research/R014.md.

3. **[R016]** National Archives and Records Administration, *Digital Preservation Strategy 2022–2026*, Strategies 4–6 and Activities 1–4. Public source; local record: sources/research/R016.md.

4. **[R015]** National Institute of Standards and Technology, *Adversarial Machine Learning: A Taxonomy and Terminology of Attacks and Mitigations*, NIST AI 100-2e2025, March 24, 2025, §3.1.1, printed pp. 36–39; §§2.3 and 3.2.1 on poisoning; §3.4 on indirect prompt injection. Public source; local record: sources/research/R015.md.

5. **[R001]** Ilia Shumailov et al., “AI models collapse when trained on recursively generated data,” *Nature* 631, published July 24, 2024, journal pp. 755–759, “What is model collapse?” and OPT-125m/WikiText-2 language-model experiment pp. 757–758. Public source; local record: sources/research/R001.md.

6. **[R003]** Matthias Gerstgrasser et al., “Is Model Collapse Inevitable? Breaking the Curse of Recursion by Accumulating Real and Synthetic Data,” arXiv version 2, April 29, 2024, §§2.1–2.3 and 3, including §2.3/Fig. 6. Public source; local record: sources/research/R003.md.

7. **[R008]** Feiyang Kang et al., “Demystifying Synthetic Data in LLM Pre-training: A Systematic Study of Scaling Laws, Benefits, and Pitfalls,” EMNLP 2025, §§4–6. Public source; local record: sources/research/R008.md.

8. **[R056]** Yusuke Nakamura et al., “Demystifying Mixed Outcomes of Self-Training: Pre-training Analyses on Non-Toy LLMs,” *Findings of the Association for Computational Linguistics: EACL 2026*, March 2026, §§2–4 and limitations. Public source; local record: sources/research/R056.md.

9. **[R009]** Bingji Yi et al., “Escaping Model Collapse via Synthetic Data Verification: Near-Term Improvements and Long-Term Convergence,” ICLR 2026 main-conference paper, published April 20, 2026, §§2–6, particularly verifier bias in §§3–4 and reference-based summarization in §5.3. Public source; local record: sources/research/R009.md.

10. **[R017]** National Archives and Records Administration, “About the Digital Preservation Program,” program overview, undated page (catalog metadata: first published September 4, 2019; modified March 20, 2026). Public source; local record: sources/research/R017.md.

11. **[S001]** Lieutenant General Paul T. Stanton, “Statement by Lieutenant General Paul T. Stanton, USA, Commander, Joint Force Headquarters – Department of Defense Information Network, Director, Defense Information Systems Agency, Before the Senate Armed Services Subcommittee on Cybersecurity,” May 21, 2025, prepared statement, PDF pp. 2–5 (“Our mission never rests,” data in modern warfighting, and distinct JFHQ-DoDIN/DISA roles, p. 2; workforce “qualified on their respective cybersecurity weapon system,” p. 3). Public source; local record: sources/stanton/S001.md.

12. **[R025]** Chief Digital and Artificial Intelligence Office, Department of Defense, “Mission and Priorities,” public mission page, accessed October 7, 2026. Public source; local record: sources/research/R025.md.

13. **[R046]** U.S. Department of Defense, *Department of Defense Records Strategy*, May 2023, §§3.1 and 4.2. Public source; local record: sources/research/R046.md.

14. **[R019]** Executive Order 14347, “Restoring the United States Department of War,” September 5, 2025, §2. Public source; local record: sources/research/R019.md. Department of Defense is used in the legislative request because this order permits secondary Department of War titles while retaining controlling statutory references; no existing authority for the proposed command is inferred.

15. **[R021]** United States Code, 10 U.S.C. §111(a), 2024 edition, subsection (a). Public source; local record: sources/research/R021.md.